It was meant to be a ‘soft focus’ interaction. As it was winding down, I wanted to ask a question on crony capitalism and the charges that he was favouring select business groups. Modi saw my hand raised, politely ignored me and ended the session. Later, I was told Modi had been assured there would be no ‘inconvenient’ issues raised. He probably thought I would rewind to 2002. Clearly, there would be no 2002-related questions and no walkouts this time!

My enduring memory of that day was Modi’s entry into the Taj Palace Hotel lobby. In his signature half-sleeved white kurta, he strode in with the self-confidence of a man who believed he had truly arrived. The BJP leaders at the venue—Smriti Irani, Meenakshi Lekhi, Piyush Goyal, Ravi Shankar Prasad, Kirit Somaiya—stood to attention, almost as if they were part of an army battalion whose general had just marched in. I tried to lighten the mood by asking Somaiya, a BJP MP from Mumbai, when he was planning to expose a CAG report on Gujarat, like he had done in Maharashtra. Modi glared at him and me. When Modi had departed the waiting room for the stage, Somaiya told me worriedly, *‘Kya boss, marva daloge mujhe!’* (Boss, you will have me killed.) Modi was still not the BJP’s prime ministerial candidate, but he was already acting like one. And party members were already both in awe and fear, already convinced that their leader was headed to victory.

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The BJP national council in March 2013 at the Talkatora Stadium in Delhi was held against the backdrop of a mini crisis in the party. Just weeks earlier, Nitin Gadkari had been forced to resign as party president over allegations of financial impropriety. Gadkari claimed in private conversation that he had been done in by the BJP’s ‘Delhi leadership’, a euphemism for the party’s parliamentary wing. Rajnath Singh was brought back to head the BJP. The council was meant to ratify his appointment. It became instead an event that showcased the emerging star power of Modi.